

VETERINARY SERVICES FOR HOUSEHOLD PETS

Appendix G: Whether LVG pet care plans provide value for money

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The Competition and Markets Authority has excluded from this published version of the final report information which the inquiry group considers should be excluded having regard to the three considerations set out in section 244 of the Enterprise Act 2002 (specified information: considerations relevant to disclosure). The omissions are indicated by [X]. Some numbers have been replaced by a range. These are shown in square brackets. Non-sensitive wording is also indicated in square brackets.

- 1.1 To assess whether LVG pet care plans provide value for money, we have reviewed information from all LVGs on their top-selling pet care plans in 2024, including the annual price of each plan, details on the treatments included, and the standalone price of each treatment and any associated services.
- 1.2 We have also reviewed information from three LVGs on treatment uptake under their respective pet care plans. Each of these three LVGs submitted that the ‘average’ plan subscriber saves money compared to buying treatments individually from their FOP. In particular:
- (a) An LVG [redacted] submitted that the majority of the LVG’s [redacted] customers save money compared to buying each core treatment individually, (and savings may be higher than this estimate, which excludes savings on other treatments only partially covered by the plan).¹ The LVG [redacted] also submitted a separate analysis to assess whether its clients obtained value for money from its top-selling dog pet care plan in the past 12 months, based on actual client consumption in 2023. This analysis showed that 85% of customers achieved cost savings compared to buying treatments on a standalone basis (indicating that 15% did not achieve cost savings on this basis).²
 - (b) Another LVG [redacted] calculated the total value of treatments used by subscribers to its national pet care plan, and found that this total value significantly exceeded the annual fees paid by subscribers of this plan. However, the LVG [redacted] also submitted that approximately 5% of customers on its pet care plans do not make use of any of the treatments included in their plan.³
 - (c) Another LVG [redacted] used annual redemption rates across 24 FOPs over three years to estimate uptake. It then estimated value based on assumptions relating to certain pet scenarios, for example ‘a female unsprayed kitten in the first year of a care plan’. Under the three scenarios it submitted, it estimated that the ‘average’ pet owner saves between £[redacted] to £[redacted].⁴
- 1.3 We note that each of these analyses is based on a comparison to a pet owner buying the relevant products and services from their FOP. They do not take into account the fact that pet owners can obtain significant savings by purchasing flea and worm parasiticide treatments online, as set out below.

¹ LVG [redacted] response to RFI14, Q1.

² LVG [redacted] response to RFI17, Q28.

³ LVG [redacted] response to RFI17, Q28.

⁴ LVG [redacted] response to RFI14, Q1.

- 1.4 Figures 1.1 to 1.4 below present our own analysis of the pricing and usage information provided by LVGs. They provide a comparison of the ‘potential’ and ‘average’ savings of each LVG’s top-selling three pet care plans (by number of subscribers).
- 1.5 We note two key caveats to our analysis:
- (a) First, we only take into account the ‘standard’ included services on LVG plans, which includes those services that are typically free or heavily discounted for subscribers. Our analysis of potential value (but not average value) also includes some additional discounts that can be obtained by plan subscribers.⁵
 - (i) These standard services differ slightly between LVGs but always include an annual vaccination (and kennel cough vaccinations for dogs), at least one consultation with a vet or a nurse,⁶ twelve months’ supply of flea and worm treatments, microchipping and neutering.⁷
 - (ii) Because we do not take into account some other discounts that can be obtained by plan subscribers, our analysis is likely to understate the value of savings that can be obtained by plan subscribers. In our analysis of potential value, we exclude discounts that were not quantified in submissions from LVGs, such as discounts on medical care and products,⁸ and our average value analysis only considers standard included services.

⁵ In our analysis of ‘potential’ value, we were able to include the following additional discounts, based on LVG responses to RF114, Q1:

- CVS’ 20% discount on health screening, discounts of 35-47% for some dental services and free nail clipping for cats and dogs.
- IVC’s 25-35% discounts on wellness screenings, 10% discount on animal health certificates, included anal gland expression, included nail clipping and included urine tests.
- Linnaeus’ included nail clipping and included anal gland expression.
- Medivet’s included annual urine screening.
- Pets at Home’s included annual basic urine screening, included seasonal tick protection, included annual general health and wellness blood screening, and £25 and £40 discounts on dental scaling and polishing for cats and dogs respectively.
- VetPartners’ 25% discount on rabies vaccination and 10% discount on selected dental procedures.

⁶ For the relevant period assessed, IVC’s ‘Essential’ plans, Medivet’s plans and CVS’ plans included one additional standalone consultation. Some of VetPartners’ plans include two consultations with a vet or nurse each year, Linnaeus’ plans included four additional consultations (two with a vet and two with a nurse), and Pets at Home’s plans included five additional consultations (two with a vet and three with a nurse). IVC response to RF114, Q1; Medivet response to RF114, Q1; CVS response to RF114, Q1; VetPartners response to RF1 14, Q1; Linnaeus response to RF114, Q1 and Pets Home response to RF114, Q1.

⁷ Our analysis does not include neutering for Medivet as the value of the discount on this treatment was not provided.

⁸ Specifically, we were unable to include the following discounts, because they were not quantifiable based on LVG responses to RF1 14, Q1:

- CVS’ 20% discount on selected medications for long-term conditions, 10% discount on all products and services and a free bag of food for every 5 bags purchased.
- IVC’s 20% discount on lifelong medications, 10% discount on dental procedures, 10% discount on selected products and diets, 10% discount on geriatric screening tests, and, for dogs on its ‘Plus’ plan, 24-hour access to an online vet and 20% discount on chronic care checkups and injections.
- Medivet’s 10% discount on all medical care (inclusive of preferred food items) and 15% discount on dental care.

- (iii) However, we consider that pet owner usage of these additional treatments is likely to be relatively low. Many of these additional treatments and services will only be required occasionally over the lifespan of the average pet and some, such as neutering and microchipping, may be taken up once, or not at all. Discounts such as chronic care checkups, dental treatments and geriatric screening tests may only be used by certain pet owners. And while 24-hour access to an online vet is likely to be beneficial for pet owners, we note that pet owners may also be able to access a range of useful information online anyway.⁹ We therefore consider that the exclusion of these treatments has a relatively small impact on our overall findings.
- (b) Second, our analysis also does not take into account the non-financial benefits of pet care plans, including that they spread costs and encourage preventative care, which may also lead to long-term financial savings and improvements in animal welfare. Evidence we have heard on this point includes:
 - (i) Linnaeus submitted that in addition to providing value for money to its clients, its pet care plans are designed to make recommended health care accessible for pet owners and drive best outcomes for pets.¹⁰ Similarly, Medivet submitted that its plan is designed to ‘maximise the welfare’ of pets.¹¹ VetPartners submitted that in addition to monetary benefits, clients also benefit from the ability to spread costs across the year and ensures pets receive recommended vaccinations and parasiticides annually.¹²
 - (ii) Most vet professionals who took part in our qualitative research felt that pet care plans were cost-effective for pet owners and improved clinical outcomes.¹³

1.6 For each pet care plan, Figure 1.1 below shows:

- (a) The potential annual savings (excluding VAT) that a pet owner could obtain by subscribing to a pet care plan and using all of the standard included

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- Pets at Home’s £10 discount on a second Seresto collar and 24-hour access to a call with a veterinary expert.
 - VetPartners’ 10% discount on selected dental procedures, 10% discount on other parasiticide treatments and 10% discount on food.

⁹ Pets at Home notes that the careline can be used for advice and where a physical examination is necessary pet owners will be referred to their practice. The careline is not suitable for use in emergency situations where pets need urgent medical care. This is set out in: [health plan terms and conditions](#) (accessed August 2025).

¹⁰ Linnaeus response to RFI17, Q30.

¹¹ Medivet response to RFI17, Q28.

¹² VetPartners response to RFI17, Q27 and Q28.

¹³ CMA veterinary professional research, p 98.

services, compared to the amount that a non-subscriber would pay at the same FOP for the same services.

- (b) The potential annual savings (excluding VAT) that a pet owner could obtain compared to non-subscribers who purchase flea and worm parasiticide treatments online. To obtain an approximate estimate of this standalone third-party online price, we compared the prices at which [X] and [X] sold their flea and worm parasiticide treatments in FOPs and at their online pharmacies.¹⁴ [X] and [X] sold these treatments online at an average discount of [X]% and [X]% per year respectively compared to the FOP price. We have therefore applied a [X]% discount to FOP prices. We then added this to the average cost of obtaining an annual prescription, which we calculated as the median prescription fee charged by each LVGs times two (because prescriptions are provided every six months).¹⁵

Figure 1.1: ‘Potential’ savings at three top-selling LVG pet care plans – compared to (1) FOP medicine prices and (2) online medicine prices at an estimated [X]% discount

[X]

Source: CMA analysis of LVG responses to RFI14, Q1.

[^] IVC’s ‘Plus’ plan includes unlimited consults. In order to provide an estimate of potential savings, we have used three annual consults as a baseline measure.

- 1.7 In response to our PDR, Linnaeus submitted that this comparison with online parasiticide prices is flawed, because: (a) the cost structures and services offered by FOPs are significantly differentiated from those of an online retailer, (b) flea and worm parasiticides are not representative of the package of services included in pet care plans, (c) most pet owners choose to purchase medicines from vet practices rather than online, and (d) this analysis does not take into account the non-financial benefits of pet care plans.¹⁶
- 1.8 However, we consider that: (a) businesses’ differing cost structures are not relevant to our assessment of whether *pet owners* obtain value for money, (b) our assessment does (in totality) take into account the broader package of services included in pet care plans, and (c) while most pet owners currently choose to purchase medicines from their vet practice, our analysis assesses whether pet care plans would provide value for money if this were to change. Overall, while we acknowledge that our value for money assessment does not take into account the non-financial benefits of pet care plans (see paragraph 1.4(b) above and 1.14 below), we consider that online parasiticide prices are a valuable comparator for pet owners considering whether to subscribe to a pet care plan.

¹⁴ [X]. The other three LVGs do not own an online pharmacy.

¹⁵ Since PDR, we have updated our prescription fee estimates, which are now based on the median fees charged (rather than weighted averages). We have also updated them in this Appendix to exclude VAT, which is consistent with the remainder of the figures in our analysis.

¹⁶ Linnaeus response to the PDR, pp.8-9.

- 1.9 The above analysis indicates that for pet owners that use all of the treatments included in their pet care plan, all of the top-selling LVG pet care plans provide significant potential savings against standalone FOP prices. When compared to a non-subscriber that obtains a written prescription and purchases flea and worm treatments online, pet care plans provide significantly lower potential savings. But for all of the top-selling LVG pet care plans, subscribers would still save money by using all the standard inclusions on their plan.
- 1.10 However, many pet care plan subscribers are unlikely to actually use all the standard treatments included in their plans. For example, microchipping and neutering are one-off requirements, and multiple additional consultations may not be required for most pet owners in a typical year. In this regard, Pets at Home submitted that the low proportion of pets on pet care plans using one or more additional consultations may be due to the fact that healthy pets typically do not require veterinary visits. It also submitted that inexperienced pet owners or those with concerns are more likely to seek additional consultations.¹⁷
- 1.11 To assess ‘average’ savings, we used estimated usage rates produced by [redacted] and [redacted], which we consider were reasonable estimates for actual consumer uptake of the treatments included in pet care plans. We did not use [redacted] usage estimates because they were provided for only 24 FOPs and were provided on a different basis than [redacted] and [redacted]. As noted above, these estimates do not consider the usage of treatments outside the ‘standard’ included benefits, so the results below may somewhat understate the average annual savings made by pet care plan subscribers.
- 1.12 Figure 1.2 presents our estimates of the average annual savings (excluding VAT) made by pet care plan subscribers, based on [redacted] and [redacted] estimated usage rates, compared to the amount that a non-subscriber would pay at their FOP for the same treatments.

Figure 1.1: ‘Average’ savings at three top-selling LVG pet care plans based on [redacted] and [redacted] usage rate data – compared to FOP medicine prices

[redacted]

Source: CMA analysis of LVG responses to RFI14, Q1, and [redacted] and [redacted] responses to RFI17, Q28.

* Pets at Home and Linnaeus provide five and four additional annual consults respectively on their pet care plans, whereas IVC and Medivet only provide average usage rates for one additional annual consult. Conservatively, we have halved these usage rate estimates when applying them to Pets at Home and Linnaeus’ additional consults.

^ IVC’s ‘Plus’ plan includes unlimited consults. In order to provide an estimate of potential savings, we have used three annual consults as a baseline measure.

- 1.13 The above indicates that the ‘average’ pet owner would save money compared to standalone FOP prices from about half of the LVGs’ top-selling pet care plans.

¹⁷ Pets at Home response to RFI17, Q28.

[X], [X] and [X] top-selling plans appear to provide, on average, positive value for money for subscribers based on this calculation, while [X], [X] and [X] top-selling plans generally do not.

- 1.14 Finally, for each pet care plan, Figure 1.3 presents the same estimates as Figure 1.2 above – but compares this against non-subscribers who purchased flea and worm parasiticide treatments online (at a discount of [X]% per year, plus the cost of obtaining a prescription, as above).

Figure 1.2: ‘Average’ savings at three top-selling LVG pet care plans based on [X] and [X] usage rate data – compared to online medicine prices

[X]

Source: CMA analysis of LVG responses to RFI14, Q1, and [X] and [X] responses to RFI17, Q28.

* Pets at Home and Linnaeus provide five and four additional annual consults respectively on their pet care plans, whereas IVC and Medivet only provide average usage rates for one additional annual consult. Conservatively, we have halved these usage rate estimates when applying them to Pets at Home and Linnaeus’ additional consults.

^ IVC’s ‘Plus’ plan includes unlimited consults. In order to provide an estimate of potential savings, we have used three annual consults as a baseline measure.

- 1.15 This indicates that when compared to a non-subscriber that purchases flea and worm treatments online, it appears that the ‘average’ pet owner would not save money by subscribing to most of the LVGs’ top pet care plans. There may be non-financial reasons for subscribing to a pet care plan when financial savings are limited. For example, some people may find it convenient to buy parasiticides from their local FOP. We consider why some pet owners choose to purchase medicines from FOPs in Part A, section 11.¹⁸
- 1.16 Figure 1.4 below presents each of the above calculations in one graph, to illustrate the difference between the various calculations of ‘potential’ and ‘average’ savings that pet owners obtain.

¹⁸ Part A, section 11: Veterinary Medicines.

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Figure 1.3: ‘Potential’ and ‘average’ savings at three top-selling LVG pet care plans based on [REDACTED] and [REDACTED] usage rate data – compared to (1) FOP medicine prices and (2) online medicine prices at an estimated [REDACTED]% discount

[REDACTED]

Source: CMA analysis of LVG responses to RFI14, Q1, and [REDACTED] and [REDACTED] responses to RFI17, Q28. Methodological notes are set out above.